

Misplaced prepositional phrases

Prepositional phrases often end up in the wrong place. If a modifier is a phrase, it should still be placed next to the person or thing it is modifying. If a prepositional phrase is placed elsewhere in a sentence, it may not convey the intended message.



Laura went for a walk with the dog **in her new boots**.



This prepositional phrase is modifying the dog, so the dog is wearing the new boots.

Laura went for a walk **in her new boots** with the dog.

This prepositional phrase is now modifying the main clause, "Laura went for a walk," so it is Laura who is wearing the boots.

- When writing, always **reread** a finished piece of text before showing it to anyone. As the writer, it's **easy to overlook** potentially **amusing** or **misleading word order**.
- A good way to check for **misplaced modifiers** in a sentence is to **single out** any **modifying words** or phrases by **underlining** or **highlighting** them. It is then easier to see which modifiers relate to which nouns, and **move** any that are in the **wrong place**.



Identifying squinting modifiers

If a modifier is placed between two phrases or clauses, it can be difficult to figure out which phrase or clause it relates to. This type of modifier is often referred to as a squinting modifier, because it looks in two different directions at the same time. The only way to resolve this ambiguity is to move the modifier so that there can be no confusion.

This adverb could be modifying the verb *swim*, in which case the sentence is saying that the people who often swim are the ones who will get stronger.

People who swim **often** will get stronger. ❌

Alternatively, *often* could be modifying the phrase "will get stronger," in which case the sentence is saying that people in general will often get stronger if they swim.

People who **often** swim will get stronger. ✅

The modifying adverb has been moved so that there is no ambiguity, and the people who often swim are the ones who will get stronger.

People who swim will **often** get stronger. ✅

The modifying adverb has been moved to avoid confusion, and the sentence is saying that people in general will often get stronger if they swim.

Dangling participles

Subordinate clauses that start with a participle often cause confusion. This type of clause must be next to its subject, which should also be the subject of the sentence. If the clause is put in the wrong place, it will modify the wrong thing; similarly, if the intended subject is left out of a sentence, that sentence will not make sense. When these errors occur, they are known as dangling participles.

Driving past, the camel was asleep.

In this sentence, the sleeping camel is doing the driving. The intended subject (the person who was driving) has been left out of the sentence.

Driving past, he saw a sleeping camel.

The sentence has been reworded so that the participle *driving* now modifies a subject, *he*, which is also the subject of the sentence.